

Chapter

Burn Your Karma Before It Burns You — The Obstacles of Sadhana and Their Remedies



Introduction: Revising the Obstacles

Every seeker on the path of sadhana meets obstacles. Some come from past karma, some from planetary periods, and some from our own speech, ego or laziness. In this discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji gives a quick **revision** of these obstacles, which he had taught earlier, one by one:

"I told you this, correct or not? Do you remember it all?
I am doing a quick revision."

With each obstacle he also gives its remedy, and at the root of almost every remedy is the same thing: **viveka-buddhi** (discerning intelligence) and **refuge in the Guru**.

1. Sanchit Karma: Burn It Before You Have to Live It

Sanchit karma is the karma accumulated from past lives that has not yet begun to bear fruit; the karma that bears fruit in this life is called **prarabdha**. The common belief is that every sanchit karma must become prarabdha and be lived through. Acharya Ji challenges this belief:

"Accumulated karma, which will be different for everyone, can become an obstacle. But who said that it ends only after it is converted into prarabdha and lived through? Burn the sanchit karma!"

He also gives the way to do it:

"So look at your horoscope, ask the Guru, attend a shivir, and burn it in advance."

Today's Action, Tomorrow's Fruit

This is not only about past lives. The fruit of today's nature is also as good as written:

"If anger comes today, then a heart attack tomorrow is certain. If you have no control, your BP will certainly rise. The end of rajoguna is suffering — life will certainly be shortened. So find a remedy for it today."

Rajoguna is the quality of nature that brings restlessness, desire and agitation; anger is one of its forms. Acharya Ji's remedy is very practical:

"You should have at least this much sense: what will happen to us from getting angry? If you must get angry, then do acting-wala anger, the kind that does not raise your BP."

To recognize karma before it becomes fruit and to remedy it in time — this is what it means to burn karma.

2. Dasha and Mahadasha: The Planets Sit in Our Relationships

In Jyotish, **dasha** and **mahadasha** are the periods in which a particular planet influences one's life. They are not in our control, and yet Acharya Ji says:

"The dasha and mahadasha are not in my hands, but some treatment can be done before the dasha arrives."

That treatment is to understand the planets, and to look for them not in the sky but around us:

"That planet does not do anything by sitting there. The relationships I have right here are all of that planet's energy. So I will have to learn how I should behave with them so that they are pleased, won't I?"

That is, the way to please the planets runs through our relationships: how we treat the people who carry that planet's energy.

Neither Good Times Nor Bad Times

Acharya Ji changes the very idea of "good" and "bad" times. The question is not whether the time is good or bad, but what is expected of me in that time:

"Not good time, bad time — what is expected of me in good time, and what is expected in bad time."

He takes the basis for this from the **Manki Gita**, which had been studied earlier:

"In it there is no such thing as good time or bad time. He dwells in every particle, He dwells in every moment. If it is the Supreme Lord alone who dwells in every moment, then how can anything be bad or good? From the angle of maya, there is bad and good; from the angle of liberation, both are good."

So every time has its own work:

"So bad times is not called bad times. That is the time for me to take vairagya and knowledge. When the time is good, it is the time for bhakti and karma, for giving charity, for doing seva."

- **Difficult times** — the time to gain vairagya (dispassion) and knowledge
- **Favourable times** — the time for bhakti, karma, charity and seva

"That mahadasha can be an obstacle for me, which can be solved with viveka-buddhi."

3. Artha: Not Just Money

The third obstacle is **artha**. Acharya Ji widens the scope of this word greatly:

"Artha — my money. But it is not just money: property, respect, society, wife, time, health. All of these can become obstacles for me."

He also describes how their lack shows up:

"Not getting respect, not having people around you, not having love at home. To do something about that, too, you will have to act with viveka-buddhi."

4. Vani: Communicating with the World and with Oneself

The fourth obstacle is our **vani**, our speech, our communication. It is through speech that we connect with the world, and most of our tension comes back to us through it:

"It is through this that we connect with the world, because of which tension comes back: 'Arre, he didn't listen to me! I'll go and give him a piece of my mind.' So how you communicate? Communicate with the self also — the inner one."

The scriptures describe four levels of speech, and Acharya Ji turns each level into a question the seeker must ask of himself or herself:

- **Para** — "How do I listen to the Guru's words."
- **Pashyanti** — "How do I listen to the voice of the 'I' within me."
- **Madhyama** — "How do I talk in murmuring, with everyone around me, small, totally gossip-wala talk."

- **Vaikhari** — "How loudly do I shout, what do I do."

5. Shravan: Wrong Listening Is Also an Obstacle

Along with speaking, listening is just as important:

"Then, how do I listen — listening can be my problem. Because of it, I can have a wrong understanding of the right scripture. Even from hearing the Guru the wrong way."

The scripture may be right and the Guru may be right, and still wrong listening can turn the meaning upside down. Acharya Ji explains this with an example from home:

"Husband and wife fighting — drawing exactly the opposite meaning. The poor woman just said something in anger, and he starts shouting: 'Your family is like this, they are poor so they are like this, you are the same, you are this!' Arre, but how did such a big meaning come out of it?"

"So that listening can be my obstacle. Shravan, manan, darshan — shravan not happening, or happening wrongly."

Shravan (listening), **manan** (reflecting on it) and **darshan** (experiencing it) — this sequence begins with shravan. If the very first step is wrong, the rest of the path goes astray too.

6. Ahankar: It Must Be Broken Like a Coconut

"Ahankar can be my obstacle. So how does ahankar go? By understanding, 'Someone is surely greater than me.'"

But here Acharya Ji points to a subtle danger:

"The ego will go, but thinking 'someone is greater than me' can also bring jealousy. That must not come either; only the ego is to be lost."

To break the ego he uses the symbol of **breaking a coconut**:

"It will go only when you break it hard, the way a coconut is broken — by reducing vasana a little, by seeing the third eye, meaning the Ajna chakra, by listening to the Guru, and then it has to be broken hard."

The **Ajna chakra** is the chakra between the eyebrows, also called the "third eye." And listening to the Guru is itself surrender:

"So listening to the Guru — that itself means sharanagati. So sharanagati is the opposite of ahankar. Only then will the ego go."

Surrender is the opposite of ego. The ego breaks not by trying to reduce it, but by taking refuge in the Guru.

7. Shraddha and Vishwas: The Obstacle of Doubt

"Then shraddha, vishwas — not having these will be an obstacle."

Acharya Ji gives the example of a doctor and medicine. Everything is available, but there is no trust:

- **Trust in the medicine, but not the doctor** — "The medicine must be good, but he must have given me poison."
- **Trust in the doctor, but not the medicine** — "Arre, the man is good, but he messes things up."

"So there should be no doubt; then the obstacles will go."

Freedom from Doubt Is Not Blind Following

Here Acharya Ji gives an important clarification:

"No doubt does not mean I said blindly follow. No doubt means first get all your doubts cleared, then start the work. But don't go into overthinking mode. If you can't make the decision, ask the Guru, that's it. And have that habit."

He also connects faith with ego: when the ego goes, faith comes on its own and doubt leaves. The basis for this is the

word of the Gita:

ajñāś cāśraddadhānaś ca saṁśayātmā vinaśyati

"The ignorant, the faithless and the doubting soul
perish."

— Bhagavad Gita 4.40

8. Pramad, Alasya and Dirghasutrata: The Obstacles of Tamoguna

Even when everything is in place and there is no doubt, one obstacle remains:

"There is all this — I have no doubt, nothing — but can there be pramad, alasya, tamoguna in me or not? And dirghasutri."

Tamoguna is the quality of nature that brings inertia, ignorance and inactivity. Acharya Ji describes three of its forms:

- **Pramad** — "Wastage of time — look at everything here and there, watch TV, watch this; not understanding one's

duty."

- **Alasya** — "Laziness."
- **Dirghasutrata** — "'We'll see later' — dirghasutri, procrastination."

"It is by doing just this that obstacles come."

Conclusion: Key Teachings

"Apart from these, you know the other obstacles; the scriptures have certainly given at least these many."

The key teachings of this discourse:

- 1 Sanchit karma can be burned before it has to be lived through.** Look at your horoscope, ask the Guru, attend a shivir. Remedy today's anger today, or tomorrow its fruit will come as illness.
- 2 The planets sit in our relationships.** The dasha is not in our hands, but behaving well with the people who carry that planet's energy is.

- 3 Time is not good or bad.** Difficult times are for vairagya and knowledge; favourable times are for bhakti, karma, charity and seva.
- 4 Artha is not just money** — property, respect, society, wife, time and health all come within it, and their lack is to be remedied with viveka-buddhi.
- 5 Look at all four levels of speech** — para, pashyanti, madhyama, vaikhari: how you communicate with others and with yourself.
- 6 Wrong listening is also an obstacle.** Wrong shravan can draw the opposite meaning even from the right scripture and the right Guru.
- 7 The ego breaks through surrender,** not through comparison; comparison can bring jealousy.
- 8 Remove doubt, but do not follow blindly.** Clear all doubts first, then start the work; no overthinking, and if you cannot decide, ask the Guru.
- 9 Pramad, alasya and dirghasutrata** — these three forms of tamoguna quietly stop one's sadhana.

The answer to every obstacle leads in one direction: **see with viveka-buddhi, and take refuge in the Guru.** Then, before karma burns us, we can burn karma.